

AI WARS

2 players · ~25 minutes · one of you saves the world — or the AI ends it for both of you

1. What is this game?

The AI race is here, and it is going badly. One of you plays **THE BUILDER**, who believes the only way to save the world is to *finish the job* — build a superintelligence, but an aligned one, before something worse escapes. The other plays **THE STEWARD**, who believes AI must be *tamed forever* — guardrails, treaties, oversight.

You are both the good guys. You are also rivals: only one vision of salvation can win. And looming over every turn is the **Doom track** — if it ever reaches 10, a rogue AI escapes and **both of you lose**.

2. Components

108 unique cards (two printable decks of 54): an 84-card **shared deck** — 12 leaders, 4 world powers, 14 models, 8 assets, 26 events, 20 guardrails — plus a 12-card **Builder agenda deck** and a 12-card **Steward agenda deck**. Plus the track board (Capability, Alignment, Trust, Doom — each 0–10), 4 track markers, and a supply of ♣ Compute and ♠ Influence tokens.

3. Setup (60 seconds)

1. Set the track markers: **Capability 2 · Alignment 2 · Trust 5 · Doom 2**.
2. Shuffle your agenda decks. The Builder takes 3♣ 3♠; the Steward takes 3♣ 5♠ (*going second pays*).
3. Shuffle the shared deck. Deal 5 cards face-up in a row: **the river**. Left end is newest; the two rightmost slots are discounted (–1 and –2).
4. The Builder goes first. (*The optimists always do.*)

4. How a round works (9 rounds total)

① **SLIDE THE RIVER.** The rightmost card falls off (discard it). Slide everything right; refill ALL empty slots from the deck. Cards get cheaper as they drift right: 4th slot –1, 5th slot –2. (*Skip in round 1 — the river was just dealt.*)

② **TAKE ACTIONS.** Starting with the Builder, alternate one action at a time until each player has taken **2 actions**. The four actions:

- **ACQUIRE** — pay a river card's cost (minus its slot discount) and take it. Leaders, models, guardrails, powers and assets go into your play area; events resolve immediately and are discarded.

- **AGENDA** — either draw 1 card from your agenda deck into your hand, **or** play 1 agenda card from your hand (pay its cost). Agendas are your side's secret tricks.
 - **GRIND** — take 2♠ or 2♣ from the supply.
 - **STEER** — pay any 3 tokens, choose one: **Alignment +1 · Trust +1 · Doom -1 · Capability +1 (Builder only)**. (*The Steward's Doom -1 choice also grants Trust +1 — told-you-so credit. Labs alone can brute-force Capability.*)
- ③ **INCOME**. Both players collect the ♠/♣ income printed on cards in their play area.
- ④ **DOOM CHECK**. Apply in order:
- If **Capability > Alignment** → Doom +1. (*Power outrunning understanding — the core danger.*)
 - If **Capability ≥ 8** → Doom +1 again. (*The frontier is inherently unstable.*)
 - If the **total printed Risk of Models in play** (both players) is **≥ 7** → Doom +1. (*A crowded frontier is unstable — Risk-reducing cards defend the whole table.*)
 - **POWER DRAW**: each player whose cards produce **3+ ♠ income** → Trust -1. (*Your datacenters are drinking rivers. The public has noticed.*)

5. Reading the cards

Every card shows its **cost** (♠ or ♣), its **VP** (victory points, for the round-8 tiebreak), and its effect. Effects starting with “*When acquired:*” happen once, immediately. Everything else is ongoing.

LEADER

Musk, Altman, Amodei, Huang, Zuckerberg, Sutskever, Hassabis, LeCun, Pichai, Nadella, Suleyman, Liang Wenfeng. Only **one active leader** each; recruiting a new one exiles the old (they leave to found a startup).

MODEL

Grok, GPT, Claude, Gemini, Llama, DeepSeek, Mistral, Qwen, AlphaFold, Sora, Gemma, Operator Agent, o-Reasoner, the AGI Prototype. Engines with **Power** (counts toward Model Supremacy) and **Risk** (feeds doom effects).

EVENT

Headlines. Resolve instantly, then discard. Buying an event nobody wants is often a defensive move.

GUARDRAIL

Ongoing protections. They count toward Global Accord — and the Builder may buy them too: a leash on your own monster is still a leash.

WORLD POWER

Trump, Putin, Xi, the UN. Unique patrons either side can court. Powerful, and they always cost you something.

ASSET

GPU clusters, legit and otherwise. Pure economy, with strings.

AGENDA

Side-only cards. The Builder scales; the Steward subpoenas.

6. Tuck — the combo engine

Any non-Event card you play may instead be **tucked** under one of your in-play cards (the *host*): slide it underneath so only its **tuck bar** (top strip) shows. The tucked card's normal text, income, Power and type are OFF — only the tuck bar applies to the host: *Host +1 Pwr, Host +1 income, Host causes no Doom, Host Risk = 0...*

- Tucked cards **keep their VP**. Maximum **2** tucked per host. Tucking is **permanent**.
- If the host leaves play, everything tucked under it is discarded too. Build tall at your own risk.
- Some cards reward tucking (Satya Nadella, Gemma, Interpretability Prize, Treaty Verification...) — that's where the combos live.

7. ►Opp: reactions

Cards with a ►Opp: line trigger during your *opponent's* actions (Whistleblower Network pays you when they buy a Model; Undersea Cable pays you when they resolve an Event...). You are never idle on the other player's turn. If timing ever conflicts, the active player resolves first.

8. Winning — the five endings

The instant any condition below is true, the game ends:

Ending	Who wins	Condition
Aligned AGI	Builder	Capability ≥ 9 and Alignment ≥ 6
Model Supremacy	Builder	3+ Models in play with total Power ≥ 8 , and Doom ≤ 4
Global Accord	Steward	Trust ≥ 9 and 3+ Guardrails in play (either side's)
Containment	Steward	Doom 0 and Capability ≥ 5 — you tamed a <i>strong</i> AI, not a weak one
Rogue AI	nobody	Doom 10 — both players lose immediately

If round 9 ends with no winner, **History Judges**: the Builder scores **min(Capability, Alignment+3) + Alignment + card VP** (unaligned capability doesn't fully count — history remembers). The Steward scores **Trust + Alignment + Guardrail count + card VP**. Highest total wins.

9. A worked turn (example)

Round 3. The river shows, left to right: GPT (4♠) · Trump (3♣) · Kill Switch Protocol (3♠) · Claude (3♠, slot -1 → pays 2♠) · Model Leak (1♣, slot -2 → free).

- **Builder, action 1**: acquires Claude for 2♠. *When acquired*: Alignment +1 — which conveniently protects the Builder's next capability push from the doom check.
- **Steward, action 1**: acquires the free Model Leak event *defensively* — it reads "Capability +1, Doom +1, Trust -1," which hurts the Steward... but leaving it there lets the Builder take it for tempo. Sometimes you buy the headline to bury it.

- **Builder, action 2:** plays agenda **Scaling Laws** (2 $\leq$): Capability +2. Capability is now above Alignment — the doom check will bite this round.
- **Steward, action 2: Steers** (pays 3): Doom -1, pre-paying for the Builder's recklessness through gritted teeth.

10. Etiquette of the apocalypse (clarifications)

- Track values never go below 0 or above 10.
- If you can't fully pay a cost, you can't take the action.
- Run out of agenda deck? The Agenda action can then only play from hand.
- The shared deck running dry just means the river shrinks — keep playing.
- "In play" always means both players' play areas combined, unless a card says *your*.
- Tucked cards are not "in play" for card types: a tucked Guardrail doesn't count for Global Accord (unless a card says so), a tucked Model isn't a Model.
- Events can never be tucked. They happen. That's the point of events.

QUICK REFERENCE

ROUND	① Slide river & refill → ② 2 actions each, Builder first → ③ Income → ④ Doom check (9 rounds)
ACTIONS	Acquire (or tuck it!) · Agenda (draw 1 or play 1) · Grind (2↖ or 2↗) · Steer (pay 3: Align +1 / Trust +1 / Doom −1 [Steward: +Trust] / Cap +1 [Builder only])
DOOM CHECK	Cap > Align → +1 · Cap ≥ 8 → +1 · total Model Risk ≥ 7 → +1 · Power Draw: 3+ ↗ income → Trust −1 (each player)
BUILDER WINS	Cap 9+ & Align 6+ —or— 3 Models, Power 8+, Doom ≤ 4
STEWARD WINS	Trust 9+ & 3 Guardrails —or— Doom 0 & Cap 5+
EVERYONE LOSES	Doom 10. The rogue AI wins. Shake hands, shuffle up, try again.
SETUP	Cap 2 / Align 2 / Trust 5 / Doom 2 · Builder 3↖3↗, Steward 3↖5↗ · river of 5 · 9 rounds
TUCK	Non-Events may play under a host (max 2): only tuck bar applies, VP kept, permanent, dies with host

AI Wars v0.3 — a Marcus & NiceDude prototype. Balance: 46/46 across 40,000+ simulated games. Both endings are saving the world; the game takes no side.